

STEPS TO OPENING YOUR LODGE: FROM COMMISSION TO CHARTER

1. Preliminary Research

- Study the Order's history, rituals, and meeting formats to understand established practices.
- Explore research on themes and symbols from the ceremonies; hold discussions on metaphorical gardening—how sowing ideas, pruning habits, and harvesting wisdom fosters individual and mutual growth in the community.
- Submit the **Request for Commission** form to the United Council (info.freegardeners@gmail.com).
- Reach out to the United Council for mentorship and guidance as needed (info.freegardeners@gmail.com).

2. Organizational Foundations

- Select a lodge name that resonates with the ceremonies, local flora, and/or principles of the Order.
- Draft bylaws using the approved template provided by the United Council, adding any Lodge specific information required by the Council or adopted by the lodge.
- Register as a nonprofit or charitable entity if required by your state/province/commonwealth, as a fraternal society or civic/social club.
- Open a dedicated bank account and establish basic accounting ([request an EIN](#) from the IRS online).
 - Required Standard for EIN and Incorporation Name: **Ancient Order of Free Gardeners – [Lodge Name and Number]**; i.e. *Ancient Order of Free Gardeners – Mount of Olives Lodge 1* (no number sign or abbreviation)
- Secure a regular meeting venue that provides a secure space where ceremonies can be held.

3. Recruitment & Member Orientation (after you receive your commission)

- Create social media accounts and a lodge email address where seekers and members can view lodge events.
- Host an open-house or informational session where seekers can meet the lodge members and learn more.
- Establish a simple interview or vetting process.
- Conduct a standard initiation ceremony using established ceremonies, and hold degree lectures for new members.

4. Program Planning & Activities

- Draft an annual calendar that includes service projects, social events, lectures/degree rehearsals, leadership training, guest speakers, and self-improvement workshops.

- Form committees for fieldwork (stewardship), study groups (metaphorical gardening), fellowship (social events) and special interests of membership (gaming, fitness, cigars, travel, etc.).
- Partner with local businesses, schools, environmental nonprofits and fraternities to co-host events that align with the principles and purpose of the Order.
- Plan a flagship service project—such as a community garden; family day at a local park; community trail walk—where members can further connect with the community
- Schedule quarterly “growth reviews” where members reflect on lessons learned and set new intentions for their fraternal journey.

5. Communication & Governance

- Set up digital channels (email list, private chat) for sharing information among members and the community.
- Schedule regular officer meetings and degree/ceremony rehearsals
- Record and distribute concise minutes of lodge meetings
- Review and update bylaws after the first year, using member feedback to enrich lodge culture.

6. Launch & Sustainability

- Hold your inaugural lodge meeting
- Publicize the lodge’s opening through local media, online groups, and community boards.
- Collect member feedback after the first quarter’s “growth review” and adjust as needed.
- Plan officer succession to ensure leadership continuity
- Create a lodge timeline documenting the charter date and members, symbolism of the lodge name, lodge leadership, special projects/events, and lodge milestones.